Gray Matter

Setup guide: the classic SI-style workflow for Blender, on Windows

You need two things: **Blender 4.2 or newer** and the file **gray_matter-0.1.0.zip**. Setup takes about five minutes. Don't unzip the file; Blender installs it as-is.

Install

1

Save the zip somewhere you can find it

Save **gray_matter-0.1.0.zip** into a folder such as **Documents\Gray Matter**. Leave it zipped.

2

Open Blender's preferences

Open Blender, then go to **Edit > Preferences**.

3

Install from disk

In the left column, click **Get Extensions**.

In the top-right corner of that page, click the small **down-arrow (v)** menu, then choose **Install from Disk...**

Browse to **gray_matter-0.1.0.zip** and click **Install from Disk**. If Blender asks about installing a third-party extension, confirm.

4

Confirm it's turned on

Click **Add-ons** in the left column and search for **Gray Matter**. The checkbox should already be ticked; if it isn't, tick it.

Click the arrow next to the name to see the add-on's options and the hotkey cheat sheet.

5

Pick your options (optional)

Classic Hotkeys: turns the SI-style keys on or off. Turn it off to get Blender's keys back.

Number Keys Open Editors: 7 / 8 / 0 open the shader editor, outliner and graph editor.

SRT Mouse Buttons: the default, Left / Middle / Right = X / Y / Z, is the classic behavior.

Preferences save automatically. If auto-save is off, click the menu at the bottom left and choose **Save Preferences**.

Set up the workspace

6 Open the MCP panel

Close Preferences and hover over the 3D viewport. Press **N** to open the sidebar on the right, then click the **MCP** tab on its right edge.

7 Click Classic Layout

Scroll to the **View** section at the bottom of the MCP and click **Classic Layout**.

You'll get four viewports (Top, Front, Right, Perspective), the MCP docked on the right, and Global orientation. Click **Four Views** to switch back to a single viewport.

8 Apply the gray theme (optional)

In the View section, click **Gray Theme** for a light-gray interface with black text, a gray viewport, black wireframes and white selection.

Click **Reset** next to it to go back to Blender's own theme. This also resets any custom theme you had, so export that first if you care about it.

Try it out

Add a cube first (**Shift+A > Mesh > Cube**), then run through these.

Space	Object selection. Click to select, drag for a box. Also leaves point/edge/polygon mode.
V / C / X	Translate / Rotate / Scale tool. Drag anywhere in the viewport, no gizmo needed.
In a V/C/X tool	Left drag = X, Middle drag = Y, Right drag = Z. Shift + Left drag = free.
T / E / Y	Point / Edge / Polygon selection on the active mesh.
S + Left / Middle / Right	Hold S, then drag: Pan / Dolly / Orbit the camera.
F / A	Frame the selection / Frame everything.
Ctrl+A	Select all.
Ctrl+D	Duplicate (move the mouse, click to place).
Ctrl+Z / Ctrl+Y	Undo / Redo.
Enter	Floating property editor for the selection.
7 / 8 / 0	Floating shader editor / Outliner (explorer) / Graph editor.

What's in the MCP

Select	Select button; Obj / Pnt / Edge / Poly modes; All, None, Invert; Select Branch; name of the selection.
Transform	S / R / T buttons activate the tools. The x/y/z fields edit values directly; the arrow on each row resets it. Global / Local / View orientation, pivot, and Prop (proportional editing).
Snap	Checkbox in the header turns snapping on; pick what to snap to.
Constrain	Parent, Cut (unparent but keep position), add a constraint, remove all.
Edit	Freeze (bakes modifiers into the mesh), Duplicate, Delete, Hide / Unhide, Center to Geometry, Reset SRT.
View	Classic Layout, Four Views, Frame Sel / All, floating Explorer / Shaders / Curves, Gray Theme.

If something doesn't work

No MCP tab	Make sure the add-on is ticked in Preferences > Add-ons, then press N with the mouse over the 3D viewport.
Hotkeys do nothing	Check that Classic Hotkeys is on in the add-on's options. The keys only work while the mouse is over the 3D viewport.
A Blender key I need is gone	Gray Matter takes over Space, S, C, V, X, E, A, F, T, Y and Enter in the 3D view. Turn Classic Hotkeys off to get Blender's back.
Middle drag doesn't work	You need a real three-button mouse. On a laptop trackpad, plug in a mouse; Blender's 3-button emulation conflicts with the classic keys.
Install from Disk is greyed out	Update to Blender 4.2 or newer (blender.org/download). Older versions can't install extensions.
Uninstall	Click Reset in the View section first if you applied the theme. Then go to Preferences > Add-ons, open the arrow next to Gray Matter and choose Uninstall.

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